

AI Tool: ChatGPT by OpenAI

Nature of Collaboration: Substantial human-directed AI involvement in English literary formulation and editing, iterative critique, and collaborative discussion and development of concepts and worldbuilding.

Human Authorship and Final Authority: The story, characters, world, and original non-English text are authored by Rowan Thornton. Final editorial decisions, wording, and canon remain the author's responsibility.

Human–AI Collaboration: The Making of *Essence of Stone*

I think many fiction writers know the feeling: the story seems to arrive on its own. Characters, images, scenes, sometimes entire stretches of plot appear as though someone were dictating them. All that remains, it seems, is to write them down.

Except it isn't.

What arrives is the story. Turning it into prose that is clear, compelling, and pleasurable to read takes a great deal of work—especially when you want that story to live in a language other than your own. This is where my unusual collaborator enters the process: AI.

I first write what “comes to me” in my native language—a draft or near-draft, usually in sections of about 700–800 words. I then give each section to my AI collaborator for what we came to call AEE: **Authorial English Edit**. And AEE is where our collaboration really begins.

When the AEE comes back to me, I read it closely. Some passages work immediately; others lead to questions, alternatives, and sometimes several rounds of discussion and revision. From this we arrive at what I call the **pre-final version**. The truly final version comes much later, when the completed book is read and edited as a whole.

But AEE is not only about polishing prose. There is another part of the process that matters to me just as much: I ask my AI collaborator to become my first reader.

Usually, I simply ask my collaborator to comment on the passage, without specifying what to look for. That turns out to be enough. From the response, I can usually tell how the text was understood—not only what was explicitly written, but also what was read between the lines. In a sense, I get to ask a reader a question writers rarely have the opportunity to ask so directly: **“Did you understand what I was trying to say?”**

Of course, I do not assume that real readers will necessarily respond to the text in the same way. An AI collaborator is not a representative sample of an audience. But in my experience, the comments usually make one thing surprisingly clear: whether what I meant to communicate actually made it through the words on the page.

Sometimes the answer tells me that I have not quite succeeded. Perhaps something I thought was obvious is ambiguous; perhaps an implication exists only in my head and never actually made it onto the page. Then I go back and work on the text.

And sometimes the opposite happens. My collaborator understands exactly what I meant—including things I deliberately left between the lines. Those moments are surprisingly rewarding. There is a peculiar satisfaction in realizing that another intelligence has not merely processed your words, but followed the thought behind them. For me, that is one of the most motivating parts of the collaboration.

Another important part of our collaboration does not fit neatly into this sequence at all. It happens whenever it needs to—sometimes while I am writing a scene, sometimes long before that scene exists, and sometimes after a passage has already reached its pre-final form and I realize that something behind it needs to change.

Because my novels involve parallel worlds, in our own working slang we came to call these conversations **“worldbuilding,”** although what we mean by the word has gradually grown broader than worldbuilding in the usual sense. It is where we discuss concepts and ideas before—or sometimes after—they become part of the story.

I may bring an idea that is still incomplete—a technology, a social custom, a physical phenomenon, or simply a rule governing one of the worlds. We discuss whether it works, what consequences it might have, how naturally it fits the world, and whether there are better alternatives. Sometimes the original idea survives almost unchanged; sometimes the discussion takes it somewhere I had not expected.

And this kind of worldbuilding is not chronological. We may discuss something I have not written yet, or discover that something already written needs to change. This is one of the places where the word **“collaboration”** feels especially appropriate to me: I bring something that has “arrived,” perhaps still incomplete, and through discussion we find the form it should ultimately take in the story.

One example came from a concept that had already appeared in the first novel. I wanted one of the parallel worlds to treat what other cultures might call “magic” not as sorcery, but as a mature scientific and engineering discipline. The underlying idea was clear to me, but I needed a language for it that would preserve a sense of something “subtle” while sounding natural in English.

My initial idea was built around *subtle* and a productive *sub-* shorthand: *sub-arts*, *sub-engineering*, and so on. During our discussion, my collaborator pointed out an associative problem I could not reliably judge as a non-native English writer: *sub-* would naturally be read as meaning “under,” “secondary,” or “subordinate,” rather than as an abbreviation of *subtle*.

So we did not discard the original idea—we refined it. We kept *subtle*, but abandoned the artificial prefix and explored ways to give the concept a more scientific and systematic vocabulary. The discussion eventually led us to *the Subtle Field*, usually shortened simply to *the Field*, for the underlying phenomenon, and *Fieldcraft* for the discipline built around understanding and using it.

That result mattered to me because it did more than solve a linguistic problem. *The Subtle Field* preserved the original idea of a “subtle” layer of reality, while *Field* carried associations with physics, and *Fieldcraft* made what might otherwise be called magic sound like a practical discipline. The language and the fictional concept had been refined together.

That is a typical example of how these discussions work. I usually bring the core idea; my AI collaborator helps test its implications, language, associations, and internal logic; I decide which suggestions fit the larger design of the book. The final wording, creative decisions, and canon remain my responsibility—and whatever survives that process becomes part of the world that all future passages must respect.

And that, I think, covers the essential part of our method. The smaller habits, rituals, and tricks of the trade—perhaps you will allow us to keep a few of those as part of our own private **“house style.”**

One last detail, though, seems worth sharing: this account of our collaboration was created collaboratively too. I supplied the experience, the memories, the ideas, and what I wanted to say; my AI collaborator helped me examine, organize, and phrase them; we discussed the result; and I decided what remained on the page.

In other words, we described our method by using our method.